

Evolution of the Debate Over Slavery, 1787-1860

1787

South

1,961,174 people (49.9% of U.S. population)

Pro-Slavery
(Slavery is good)

Compromise: Ignore it
(This issue will resolve itself)

1,968,040 people (50.1% of U.S. population)

North

Abolition
(Slavery is evil)

1820

South

4,485,818 people (46.5% of U.S. population)

Pro-Slavery
(Slavery is good)

Compromise: Missouri Compromise of 1820
(Keep number of slave and free states equal)

5,152,635 people (53.5% of U.S. population)

North

Colonization
(Back to Africa) | Abolition
(Slavery is evil)

1840

South

7,334,431 people (43.0% of U.S. population)

Pro-Slavery
(Slavery is good)

Compromise: Missouri Compromise of 1820
(Keep number of slave and free states equal)

9,728,922 people (57.0% of U.S. population)

North

Free Soil
(Only free labor in new states) | Abolition
(Slavery is evil)

1850

South

9,664,656 people (41.7% of U.S. population)

Pro-Slavery
(Slavery is better than factory labor)

Compromise: Popular Sovereignty
(Let new states decide for themselves)

13,527,220 people (58.3% of U.S. population)

North

Free Soil
(Reserve new states for free labor) | Abolition
(Slavery is evil)

1860

South

12,315,373 people (39.2% of U.S. population)

Pro-Slavery
(Slavery is better than factory labor)

Squatter Sovereignty
(The people will decide)

19,127,948 people (60.8% of U.S. population)

North

Free Soil
(Reserve new states for free labor) | Abolition
(Slavery is evil)